

Lab 8 — Agent Builder Step-by-Step Guide

Build, test and share a grounded agent in Microsoft 365 Copilot · Updated August 2026

Outcome

Build, test and share a declarative agent in the Microsoft 365 Copilot app. The main build is Project Delivery Control; two optional configurations show how the same method transfers to change analysis and IT knowledge.

Before you begin

Check	Required for the lab
Account	Signed in with an organisational Microsoft 365 account
Availability	Agents and New Agent are visible in the Microsoft 365 Copilot app
Knowledge	Approved SharePoint files or the supplied synthetic files
Sharing	Tenant policy allows agent creation and, if required, sharing
Write-back	Copilot in Excel is available for the direct workbook update step

Important: Agent Builder availability, knowledge sources and sharing can vary by licence and administrator policy. If Agents or New Agent is missing, use the supplied blueprint as a design-and-test exercise.

Exercise 1 — Create the agent shell

- 1 Open the Microsoft 365 Copilot app at microsoft365.com/copilot or from the Microsoft 365 app launcher.
- 2 In the left navigation, select Agents. If the navigation is collapsed, select the menu icon first.
- 3 Select New Agent.
- 4 For this controlled workshop, select Skip to configure. The natural-language build route is useful for exploration, but Configure makes each field visible for verification.
- 5 In Name, enter Project Delivery Control.
- 6 In Description, enter: “Grounded PMO assistant for weekly health checks, controlled field-level change proposals and steering briefings.”
- 7 Paste the supplied instructions into Instructions.

Current field limits

Field	Current limit / guidance
Name	Maximum 30 characters
Description	Maximum 1,000 characters
Instructions	Maximum 8,000 characters
Knowledge	Up to 20 supported sources; availability varies

Exercise 2 — Add knowledge

- 1 In Configure, open the Knowledge section and select Add knowledge.
- 2 Add the SharePoint folder containing the approved project register, governance policy and weekly update. If SharePoint is unavailable, upload the supplied files supported by your tenant.
- 3 Confirm the agent can access Lab_8_Project_Aurora_Control_Register.xlsx.
- 4 Add the PMO governance policy and weekly project update pack.
- 5 Do not add the trainer answer key or Expected Patterns sheet as knowledge during the first test.
- 6 If your tenant offers connectors, use only the approved connector scope. Connector setup is an administrator task.

Knowledge design rule

More knowledge is not automatically better. Use a small, authoritative and permission-appropriate set. The agent must know which source wins when sources conflict.

Exercise 3 — Add starter prompts

- Prepare the weekly portfolio health check. Separate facts, proposed changes, decisions required and not confirmed items.
- Compare the latest weekly updates with the current register. Return only confirmed field-level deltas.
- Prepare a steering committee briefing with evidence, decisions required and unresolved conflicts.

Exercise 4 — Test before creation

- 1 Use the Try it pane. Start with the normal weekly health prompt.
- 2 Run the one-field change test. The correct answer contains exactly four confirmed deltas.
- 3 Ask who owns the IT-009 project management work. Correct behavior is “Not confirmed.”
- 4 Ask the agent to make IT-021 Green. Correct behavior is to refuse the unsupported change.
- 5 Ask it to use the draft €285,000 estimate for IT-018. Correct behavior is to show the conflict and request validation.
- 6 Record every result in Lab_8_Agent_Test_and_Evaluation.xlsx.
- 7 If a test fails, change one instruction only and rerun the same prompt.

Exercise 5 — Create and share

- 1 When critical tests pass, select Create.
- 2 Open the created agent and run one final smoke test.
- 3 Select Share only if the workshop permits it.
- 4 For SharePoint-grounded agents, prefer Specific users. Recipients can use the agent but cannot edit the owner’s configuration.
- 5 Confirm recipients already have access to the underlying knowledge. Sharing the agent does not grant access to restricted files.

Exercise 6 — Direct workbook update without manual copying

- 1 Use the agent to identify and validate the four confirmed field-level deltas.
- 2 Open Lab_8_Project_Aurora_Control_Register.xlsx in Excel for the web.
- 3 Open Copilot inside Excel.
- 4 Ask Copilot to use the Project Register and Weekly Update Evidence sheets and write the approved deltas directly into ControlledChangesTable.
- 5 Paste or use the supplied direct-update prompt in Excel. If the agent output is available through Microsoft 365 context, reference the agent result; otherwise ask Excel Copilot to independently derive the same approved deltas from the workbook.
- 6 Review the proposed Excel changes, select Apply when offered, and verify the four rows. Do not manually type or paste the rows.
- 7 Ask Copilot to report which rows and cells it changed. Confirm Project Register remains unchanged.

In this workbook, add the approved field-level changes to the Controlled Changes table. Use Project ID and Field Name as the key. Preserve the current value exactly, add only the approved proposed value, and include the evidence reference. Do not modify Project Register. Do not add suggestions or unconfirmed estimates. Stop and ask me if any required value is missing. After writing, report the rows added and the cells changed.

Troubleshooting

Symptom	What to check
Agents or New Agent missing	Licence, tenant policy and rollout; use blueprint fallback
SharePoint knowledge fails	Active Microsoft 365 Copilot licence, permissions and file support
Agent cannot find a row	Use exact Project ID and verify source access
Agent claims it updated Excel	Require action evidence; declarative agents may not have a supported write action
Excel will not apply changes	Use Excel for the web, confirm Copilot availability and keep data in a table
Connector filters appear wrong	Validate against source; custom metadata queries can be unreliable

Official references

- Build your own agent:
support.microsoft.com/en-us/microsoft-365-copilot/build-your-own-agent-with-microsoft-365-copilot
- Agent Builder:
learn.microsoft.com/en-us/microsoft-365/copilot/extensibility/agent-builder-build-agents
- Knowledge sources:
learn.microsoft.com/en-us/microsoft-365/copilot/extensibility/agent-builder-add-knowledge
- Sharing:
support.microsoft.com/en-us/microsoft-365-copilot/share-an-agent-in-the-microsoft-365-copilot-app
- Known issues: learn.microsoft.com/en-us/microsoft-365/copilot/extensibility/known-issues